

"Let me walk you through us..."

~ read together · check your tree · the tree does not have to be perfect, it has to be honest ~

1

GENERATION 1 · HOW WE BEGIN

*From Fujian · the chalk line*1872
–1923

My great-grandfather is the man who stepped off a Fujian boat at George Town at nineteen with one trunk and a **brass pocket-watch** in his palm — **Tan Keo San** (*my Tua-Kong, #1*). He worked the docks for seven years, then built our shipping house **See Hai Chan 西海棧**, and set the rule that runs us still: *"the eldest son carries both the books and the time."*

My great-grandmother is the eldest of the three **Yap goldsmith** sisters of Beach Street — **Yap Eng Siew** (*my Tua-Ma, #2*) — who walked into his house in 1898 already wearing the **Ibu** brooch. She had two younger sisters, the **Three Golden Orchids 三朵金蘭**: the middle, **Yap Eng Neo** (*#4*), who married the cloth merchant **Lee Poh Soon** (*#6*) in 1901 and wore the **Anak A** brooch from her wedding day; and the youngest, **Yap Eng Hooi** (*#5*), who never married and died in the winter of 1923 at twenty-three. Her **Anak B** brooch went into a small enamel tin. *Or so the family was told.*

In 1920 my great-grandfather brought a second woman under his roof — **Auntie Mei, Lim Mei Lan 林美蘭** (*#3*). My Tua-Ma drew a **chalk line across the kitchen floor** on her first morning and meant every inch of it. Auntie Mei stayed behind that line for seventy-six years.

★ card 1 of 4 · founders & the chalk line ★

2

GENERATION 2 · TWO SONS, TWO DOORS

*The wedding of 1947*1918
–1950

My great-grandfather had two sons by the two women. The front son is my grandfather — **Tan Cheng Hoe** (*#7*) — born 1920 to Tua-Ma, raised with her keys at her hip and the brass watch ticking in the next room. He inherited both at twenty-one. The back son was the one whose name the front of the house never said: **Tan Ah Cai** (*#9*), born to Auntie Mei in 1925; the wharf men called him **Seoy Yee Kia 細姨仔** — *"the mistress's son."* He joined the resistance in 1942 and walked into the **jungle north of Kulim** after the surrender in 1945. We have waited eighty-one years.

My grandfather married **Lee Beng Guat** (*my Ah Ma, #8*) in 1947 — *"a Penang–Penang alliance"* his mother arranged with the words: *"She is the one. Do not ask further."* Beng Guat was born in winter 1921 in the **back room of the goldsmith house**, raised by the Lees, but pinned with the **Anak B** brooch on her seventh birthday by her own mother — Eng Neo — who told her never to let it leave her. On her wedding morning Tua-Ma lifted the **Ibu** from the tin onto her collar; her mother pinned **Anak A** beside it; **Anak B** was already there. The kerongsang was complete on one collar for the **first time in twenty-four years**.

Beng Guat's elder brother is **Lee Boon Kuan** (*#12*) — the only

★ card 2 of 4 · the wedding of 1947 · the brooches reunited ★

3

SINGAPORE + GENERATION 3 · THE WATCH SLIDES ACROSS

*"You keep the time. I keep the books."*1948
–1995

In 1948 the families arranged a **Penang–Singapore alliance: Tan Chen Neo** (*my grandaunt, #11*) was sent across the causeway at twenty-three to marry the Singapore shipping tycoon **Khoo Chin Nam** (*#10*), already a widower with a grown son. Eleven months later his heart stopped at his own breakfast table. She refused to come home. She stayed in his Singapore house, learned **kasut manik** beadwork from her stepson's mother-in-law, and became — by sixty — the named master of three showrooms; her **peony-toe** pattern hangs in the Peranakan Museum on Armenian Street.

My grandparents had two sons. The elder is my **Tua-Pek Albert — Tan Soon Fatt** (*#13*) — who took an English name in Sydney, listed See Hai Chan on Bursa in 2008, and on the night their father died in 1995 pushed the brass watch across the table to his younger brother and said: *"You keep the time. I will keep the books."* He married **Alice Wong** (*#14*) of KL — Wharton, banking, Catholic — at **St Andrew's Cathedral, Singapore**, in a white gown.

That younger brother is my father — **Tan Soon Heng** (*#15*) — architect, restorer of seventeen Penang shophouses including the See Hai Chan godown on Beach Street; he has wound the

4

GENERATION 4 · TONIGHT

*"...and now there is me"*1990
–today

My Tua-Pek's only son is my cousin **Kelvin Tan — Tan Kai Wen** (*#20*) — Singapore-born, Melbourne-schooled, London-financed; he knows the See Hai Chan balance sheet by heart and could not name three of his great-aunts. He is, on paper, his father's heir.

My only brother is **Dr Tan Wei Wen** (*#18*) — internal medicine at Penang General — who met his wife **Khoo Hooi Wen** (*#19*) at a Singapore heritage conference in 2017. Hooi Wen is the **great-granddaughter of Khoo Chin Nam** through his Singapore **first** marriage. When Aunt Chen Neo, then 92, recognised both family names over Sunday lunch she said: *"You are the Tan boy. She is my husband's grand-girl. Sit down. I have been waiting seventy years for this dinner."* They married in 2020. Hooi Wen wore Aunt Chen Neo's **1948 peony-toe slippers** under her own kebaya — the first time those slippers had been worn since the eleven-month marriage ended.

And me — I am **Bibi Rose · 陳玫瑰** (*#17*), daughter of Soon Heng & Soo Hui, host of tonight. I wind my father's watch every morning at six since his stroke in 2024. I found my grandmother's **enamel tin** on the highest shelf of the bridal cupboard in 1998 and waited twenty-six years to open it. Tonight I have lifted the **nine-dumpling kamcheng** down

★ card 3 of 4 : the watch : the cookbook : the Singapore

★ card 4 of 4 : tonight : 26 hearts : 1 family ★